cies in the world have employed. Even Pakistan doesn't keep AN-94s, so how it washed up in dusty Jawaharke is a mystery in itself. Anyway, the police's older-generation armoury—AK-47s, 303s and LMGs—pales in comparison.

The proliferation of weaponry is no figment of the imagination. On May 10, Punjab Police's intelligence HQ in Mohali was hit by a Chinese-made RPG. "It's alarming this weapon has reached here. It means the gangsters may have links with global syndicates," says ex-DGP Shashi Kant. The RPG, a common sight in the Afghan and Syrian conflicts, had never been used by Khalistani outfits before. Intelligence officials say it may have reached Naxal groups too, who still have a fragmented support base in Punjab. In January, Gurdaspur police recovered an under-barrel grenade launcher (UBGL) in Dinanagar that had been air-dropped via drones, apparently by Rode's men.

THE BIRTH OF GANGS

The first gangster of modern-day Punjab, Prabhjinder Singh a.k.a. Dimpy Chandbhan, shot to fame after killing student leader Makhan Singh in 1985. Singers then were already idolising him with lines like *Ni tedi pagg banne Dimpy Chandbhan wargi* (He wears a tilted turban like Chandbhan). But such songs remained hyper-local, playing around Dimpy's native Faridkot. Lately, Moosewala's refurbished version, 'Malwa Block', became a global hit. Dimpy was killed outside Chandigarh's Lake Club in 2006—Punjab's first 'gang war'. His friend-turned-foe Jaswinder Singh, alias Rocky Fazilka, was said to have had a role. The duo, once part of don-politician Mukhtar Ansari's network of hired guns, had fallen out after escaping from a Haryana jail in 2005.

Rocky then came to dominate Punjab's organised crime scene, before drifting towards politics—while still controlling protégés like Lakha Sidhana and Lawrence Bishnoi. Rocky contested the 2012 assembly polls from Fazilka, and while Akali Dal cadre on the ground favoured him, SAD chief Sukhbir Badal intervened to ensure the BJP's Surjit Kumar Jyani won. Rocky also bonded with liquor baron Shiv Lal Doda, who earned infamy with the brutal murder of Dalit activist Bhim Tank in 2015. Sidhana contested the recent assembly polls from Maur Mandi under Balbir Rajewal's farm union-led Sanyukt Samaj Morcha; Rocky's sister Rajdeep Kaur flitted from SAD to the Congress and is now with Amarinder's Punjab Lok Congress. Rocky's own comet-like life came to an end in a gangland shootout at Parwanoo, Himachal Pradesh, in May 2016. The hand of erstwhile companions, including Harjinder Singh Bhullar alias Vicky Grounder, was suspected.



TRIGGER HAPPY
A social media post from 2016 of the 'Grounder Gang'

BERETTA PISTOLS, ASSAULT RIFLES, ROCKET-PROPELLED GRENADES, EVEN THE 1,800-BPM AN-94... PUNJAB SEEMS TO BE AWASH WITH ARMS

Grounder—a state-level discus thrower and a product of Government Arts & Sports College, Jalandhar, one of the finest sports schools in north India, some of whose alumni like hurdle runner Lahoria and hammer thrower Jaipal were his comrades-in-arms—had earned his moniker for the time he used to spend at the sports ground. Grounder's notoriety peaked with the infamous Nabha jailbreak of 2016, where pro-Khalistan militants Harminder Mintoo and Kashmir Singh Galwandi were among the escapees. Both Grounder and Lahoria were killed at the Rajasthan border in 2018—part of Amarinder's collection of scalps—while Jaipal met his end in a dramatic encounter at Kolkata in a joint op with West Bengal police. This group, now led by Gurpreet Sekhon from jail, works in tandem with Bishnoi's gang. Today, Goldy Brar is the de facto CEO of the Bishnoi gang—he conducts his 700-strong 'workforce' from Toronto in Canada, with the help of Lawrence's cousin Sachin Bishnoi. Lawrence, arrested in 2016, is cooling his heels in Tihar jail, named in over two dozen cases. His gang is nowhere close to the heights Rocky or Chandbhan had reached, but is in the process of establishing itself as the dominant player in north India.

One curious mainstay of gangs is the kabaddi circuit, which is big with the diaspora. Tournaments span the geographical gamut from rural Punjab to Canada, UK, US, Australia and Europe—perfect, therefore, for human trafficking, or what they call *kabootar-baazi*. Bishnoi's own flight to gangsta stardom was marked by news that he had planned to bump off Salman Khan during the shooting of *Ready*, apparently over his community's anger with the blackbuck case. That spectre raised its head again last week when cops found a letter near Khan's home threatening to eliminate him. On June 8, the ninth arrest in the Moosewala case came from Pune Rural: of shooter Sourabh Kamble alias 'Mahakal'. The last gunshot has perhaps not been heard. ■